

What Landlords Actually Check

Written from the agent's side of the table. Screening isn't a mystery — it's 5 checks, in roughly this order. Once you know what each check sees, you can fix or counter every one of them.

Check 1: Your Credit Report

What they see: score, collections (medical, utility, phone), charge-offs, bankruptcies, payment history, total debt. Big property managers use hard cutoffs (commonly 600–650). Private landlords usually just skim for disasters.

What hurts most: unpaid UTILITY and RENT-RELATED collections — to a landlord, that's you not paying housing bills. A maxed credit card scares them less than a \$300 PGW collection.

- Fast move #1: pay or settle small utility/telecom collections first — biggest screening impact per dollar
- Fast move #2: get your free reports at annualcreditreport.com and dispute genuine errors (they're common)
- Fast move #3: start rent reporting / credit building now — the renters who do this are 40–60 points higher in 6 months [MORGAN: affiliate links]
- Can't fix in time? Get ahead of it with the Low Credit explanation letter + Script 4

Check 2: Eviction History

What they see: court FILINGS, not just judgments — even cases you won or that were withdrawn can appear.

Your rights in Philly (Renters' Access Act): landlords must give you written screening criteria BEFORE taking your application or fee. They cannot consider evictions 4+ years old, cases they didn't win, or pandemic-era nonpayment. They cannot auto-deny on an eviction record — an individualized assessment is required.

If you're denied anyway: they must send a written letter explaining why. You then have 48 hours to request reconsideration and up to 7 business days to submit evidence (proof a case was dismissed, payment records, your explanation letter). Most renters never use this — the ones who do, win reversals.

- Pull your own background check once so you know exactly what they'll see — no surprises
- If a filing was dismissed/withdrawn: say so in writing, attach proof
- Use the Past Eviction letter in this package — proactively
- Note: PA does not currently allow sealing eviction records — managing the narrative is your tool, and it works

Check 3: Income & Employment

What they do: calculate gross income vs 3x rent, then verify — pay stubs, bank deposits, and often a call to your employer just to confirm you work there.

- Make sure whoever answers your employer's phone knows you (warn your manager, like a job reference)
- Deposits should roughly match claimed income — landlords notice when they don't

Check 4: The Previous-Landlord Call

The sneaky one: smart landlords call your PREVIOUS landlord, not your current one. Your current landlord might praise a bad tenant to get rid of them. The previous one has no reason to lie.

What they ask: Did they pay on time? Any damage beyond wear and tear? Complaints from neighbors? Would you rent to them again?

- That last question — “would you rent to them again?” — decides it. Know what your last two landlords will say BEFORE you apply
- On bad terms with a past landlord? Address it in your explanation letter before they hear it cold on a phone call

Check 5: The Eye Test

Private landlords especially are deciding one thing at the tour: “will this person be easy?” On time, polite, asks practical questions (trash day, utilities, parking — not “what if I’m late on rent”), follows up same day. It sounds small. It has tipped more borderline applications than any credit score.

Private Landlord vs. Big Property Manager

	Private landlord	Property mgmt co.
Credit score	Flexible, skims for disasters	Hard cutoff, automated
Explanation letters	Often decisive	Rarely read
Voucher process	Varies, relationship-driven	Formal, slower, consistent
Speed of decision	Same week, sometimes same day	3–10 business days
Negotiating room	Real (deposit, move-in date)	Almost none

If your profile has issues, your odds are dramatically better with private landlords — that’s where letters, references, and the eye test actually get weighed.

Fix Things in This Order

1. Know what they’ll see: pull your own credit + background once
2. Kill small utility/rent collections first
3. Line up references and warn them
4. Write your explanation letter(s) now, not at midnight before an application
5. Start credit building today — it pays off on your NEXT lease too
6. Target the right landlords for your profile (see table above)